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# Geographies and counter-geographies of global circulation in port cities – the case of Piraeus

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**ABSTRACT**
At a time of global logistical restructuring and a rising concentration of corporate power over ports, the local territories of port cities are increasingly experiencing contested geographical reconfigurations. This article interrogates the politics of circulation and these resulting contested geographies in port cities through an examination of the paradigmatic case of Piraeus, Greece. Drawing on qualitative research and perspectives from inhabitants engaged in contestation, this article analyzes how power, social and ecological relations are reconfigured by the privatizations and expansion of the port of Piraeus. It engages with the broader paradigm of supply-chain urbanism, showing how the circulation of goods and related speculative investments are refashioning local urban geography. The city's structural reshaping has been met by social mobilizations that reveal the promise of environmental justice approaches that bridge community differences across Piraeus' fragmented territory. Grassroots environmental monitoring is producing the conditions for new relationships, expanding the terrain of political action and knowledge for charting shared imaginaries across port cities' counter-geographies.

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## Introduction. Urbanizing circulation in Piraeus

On a sunny morning in May 2022, an unusual sight appeared in the bay of Piraeus, home to the largest port city in Greece. A small boat, with one Greek flag flapping on its sail, was bobbing along sea waters usually navigated by large ferries and ships. A small group of people on board waved a banner, behind them was a freshly graffiti-ed slogan scrawled across a half-completed port terminal: *οχι λιμανι εδω* ("No port here"). This water-bound action by the citizens' movement "No port in Piraiki" occurred during a heated moment in the Supreme Court, one many had thought impossible: it had declared the expansion of the recently privatized port of Piraeus, including its new cruise terminal, illegal. The declaration was welcomed by "No port in Piraiki" who had also contested the project because of a lack of any strategic environmental assessment (SEA) for the project. The EU Directive on the SEA aims at guaranteeing a high level of environmental protection, and identifies public participation as a key condition. COSCO, the corporation that had acquired Piraeus port authority in 2016, then had to pause construction until a new legal version of the masterplan was presented.

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This was a temporary, but encouraging, victory for the citizens' struggle against COSCO's masterplan, which intends to reorganize and expand the port of Piraeus. The masterplan is part of the logistical restructuring that followed the privatization of the port authority, which had been putting unprecedented pressure on local communities in terms of spatial, social and ecological relations, while transforming their lived environments.

Piraeus' contemporary moment – embedded in large networks of Chinese-funded logistical infrastructure and transnational circulation as struggles for workers' rights and right to the city intensify – renders it paradigmatic of a contemporary port city under reconfiguration. As freight has increased in volume and accelerated in speed, new urban geographies are emerging from logistics restructuring. Urban spaces in port cities across the Global North and South have been refashioned as key nodes along global commodity circuits, configuring what Danyluk (2021) has defined as "supply-chain urbanism" – a distinctive paradigm of urbanization emerging from logistics restructuring. Continuous port expansion is adopted through imbalanced power mechanisms, altering urban geographies and everyday life without citizens' consent, triggering social contestation.

This article frames Piraeus as a city where "circulation is urbanized" (Cowen, 2014, p. 184), contributing to understandings of what forms of urbanization emerge from logistical transformation, and how this triggers political resistance and alternative grassroots imaginaries. It interrogates how the full privatization of the port – an atypical, but growing mechanism that transfers asset ownership (including land) to a privately owned company (Notteboom et al., 2022) – is refashioning the urban geography of Piraeus. I expand on ongoing debates exploring the production of urban space by supply chains, focusing on how the port is appropriating space from the city, altering pre-existing spatial, social and ecological relations. The analysis illustrates the forces and mechanisms through which the city is being restructured to facilitate commodity and capital circulation. It highlights how the circulation of speculative investment that exceeds port infrastructure – in this case towards cruise-related tourism – refashions the city's geography together with the circulation of goods.

At the heart of the article's analytical commitments are the emerging forms of contestation, in particular social mobilizations that offer the potential to bridge political, economic, and geographical differences. By examining the actions of inhabitants engaged in contestation, this article shows how the privatization of the port has produced unprecedented conditions for contestation, as well as for socio-ecological innovation. Considering practices of political resistance developed around environmental justice, this case expands socio-ecological perspectives of the supply-chain urbanism paradigm. The article positions port cities geography within critical debates in geography, considering them as crucial sites in the politics of circulation – where power, social and ecological relations are reconfigured by the movement and flow of goods, information and capital across different spaces.

In the next section, I outline a literature review that puts into dialogue an urban political ecology of port city transformation together with critical geography focusing on logistics and the politics of circulation. The section "Approaching geographical transformations in Piraeus" introduces the ethnographic methods implemented for this analysis. The section "Geographies of port privatization" examines the alliances that came to

push for aggressive port privatization and expansion, and the materialization of the new socio-spatial order through the port masterplan. The section "A counter-geography of Piraeus" examines the forms of contestations and social mobilizations that emerged against the port restructuring, offering a view on grassroots environmental monitoring as a vehicle for counter-geography. The conclusion summarizes these insights for the conceptual debate on the contested reconfiguration of socio-spatial relations in port cities during a time of global logistics expansionism.

## Reconfiguring port cities: contested geographies of global circulation

Spatial and environmental inequalities, justice and social change have become emerging and ubiquitous issues in the ongoing, turbulent reconfiguration of port cities. Port infrastructure has become increasingly privatized and corporatized, with a small cluster of shipping corporation alliances strongly influencing port governance (Merk, 2013). The decisions of corporatized port authorities concerning port infrastructure are no longer necessarily aligned with the needs of cities and their citizens, partly because the complex spatial and financial restructuring driven by global logistical dynamics render port cities progressively difficult to govern through standard democratic processes (Savoldi, 2024).

The last four decades have seen the spatial, social and economic disintegration of the relationship between port and city (Hoyle, 2000; Mah, 2014; Ducruet & Lee, 2006). Particularly because of globalization and containerization, ports have become increasingly economically integrated with global supply chains, and environmentally disruptive and disconnected from their urban areas (Notteboom et al., 2022). The relational breakup, which is both urban and ecological, is accelerating with the ongoing global expansion of logistics. The inexorable port expansion generates conflicts of resources between port and city, as ports demand more space, water and energy. Port expansion is causing diverse environmental conflicts over biodiversity conservation, coastal defense and port-generated risks and hazard, land-use change and over-access (Bartłomiejski, 2016). The environmental impacts of these conflicts alter the long-held interdependency between the city and the surrounding ecosystem. While citizens of port cities experience intensified environmental toxification and health issues through air pollution, noise and congestion (Matsuoka et al., 2011) community displacement is also common (Lombard et al., 2021). Even if port and city authorities are aware of air, noise, water pollution, waste as serious issues (Roberts et al., 2023) a general lack of critical and accessible data on the environmental impacts of marine traffic and port activity remain common across many port cities.

The growth imperative intrinsic to maritime logistics has prompted a production overcapacity (Bologna, 2017), which is turning ports into bearers of uneconomic growth for their host localities – meaning that, in spite of an appearance of positive growth on the surface, a decline in overall quality of life occurs due to significative environmental and social impacts (Nogué- Algueró, 2020). As "metabolic vehicles", ports rapidly speed up social metabolism through energy and materials consumed in the city (Virilio, 2006) and the generation of urban environments. Social metabolism indicates the process of biophysical inflows and outflows that sustain society through the extraction, transformation and consumption of energy and material (Martinez-

Alier et al. 2010). As Kaika and Swyngedouw (2014) remind us, these metabolic vehicles are driven by governing arrangements that ensure the incremental expansion of the capital circulation process. Huge port expansion projects are being uncovered as white elephant projects, that always put pressure on neighboring spaces in which residents suffer and workers toil (Bond et al., 2016). An analytical focus on who gets what environmental burden and benefit helps us visualize what Martinez-Alier and O'Connor term the "ecological distribution conflict" – a conflict over the social distribution of environmental costs and benefits deriving from the interchange between societies and nature (Martinez-Alier and O'Connor, 1996). Studies in Los Angeles, USA, for example, have shown how poorer and minority ethnic communities, many living in working-class enclaves, suffer disproportionately from the port industry's expansion, triggering community-based environmental justice movements (Hricko et al., 2014). The online platform ContestedPorts.com, which maps cases of civic resistance against port expansion across the world, visualizes a growing geography of community conflicts in port cities, embedded in rising global circulation. Environmental justice is a main concern in these struggles, within the broader context of socio-ecological matters. This is interconnected with the spread of civic concern over the commons – Teschner (2018) has highlighted how port cities tell a tragic story about the use and management of the urban coastal land, with port and city competing over valuable resources, with economic, environmental, and social justice implications.

The question of ports, transnational circulation and the contested transformation of urban space have been explored by authors that critically engage with logistics. A growing body of literature interrogates how the politics of financial, corporeal and material movement reorganizes spatial and social relations with and against profit and power (Chua et al., 2018). Looking at logistics cities as a new global urban form, Cowen (2014) underlines how they transform time, space and territory, producing juridic forms and spatial reconfigurations through conflictual processes. Framing logistics as a part of the production process itself, this author sees ports as the stage where tensions between global flows and fixity manifest and reformulate the relationships between making and moving.

Issues of socio-spatial and environmental justice emerging in port cities are an expression of the deep entanglements of urban development and global logistics. Their ongoing and contested reconfiguration reveals insights of the "supply-chain urbanism" paradigm. As Danyluk (2021) observed, with the development of global logistical systems, cities around the world are being conceived as nodes in circuits of commodity capital. These efforts reshape their geography in name of smooth and efficient circulation, producing space through racial and class dispossession and exploitation, and provoking novel forms of political resistance. The violence embedded in global trade and the logistics supply chain (Cowen, 2014) shapes violent cartographies of urban space. Jenss (2020), examining the case of Buenaventura, Colombia, has highlighted how the port is directly implicated in the production of violent urban spaces. He argues that privatized economy of the Buenaventura's port and society are built into the same urban fabric, though they have different economic circuits that are precariously linked. Going beyond the argument of the port's use as a drug trade gateway, Jenss indicates the falsehood of the promise of socio-economic prosperity made by those invested in the port economy.

The forms that political resistance to logistical restructuring take have been approached by several authors through discourses on disruption, blockade and solidarity formations along the supply chains (Bosworth & Chua, 2021; Alimahomed-Wilson & Ness, 2018; Cole, 2018; Cowen, 2014). Bernes (2013), conceiving the port as an interface between workers and capital in circulation, defines the blockade at the port as a counter-logistics project against capital flows. Interrupting transnational circuits breaks the illusion that capital circulate without friction, resistance or violence (Chua, 2014). Disruptions, which resist logistical circulation, are active reorientations that attempt to produce an alternative regime of governance (Davis, 2021). With the emergence of supply-chain urbanism as a logistics-driven paradigm of urbanization that reinforces existing patterns of socio-spatial inequalities, novel forms of political resistance are emerging – their potential still coming to light (Danyluk, 2017, p. 164). The case of Piraeus shows the potential of environmental justice as a concept around which political resistance is organized. Grassroots monitoring is foregrounded as a terrain of political and legal claim-making, creating a common ground across fragmented communities in the pursuit of counter-geographies.

## Approaching geographical transformations in Piraeus

Piraeus port is the largest passenger port and one of the largest container ports of the Mediterranean Sea, covering around 35 km of coastline (Figure 1). Until the 1821 Revolution, the port was surrounded only by a few shacks, a monastery and a customs office. It was only after the creation of the municipality in 1835 that residents from the islands and the Peloponnese moved there to work. At the beginning of the twentieth century, together with industrialization, the population grew to 75,000 inhabitants (Bafouni, 2007). The population of Piraeus doubled in the 1920s with the arrival of Greek refugees

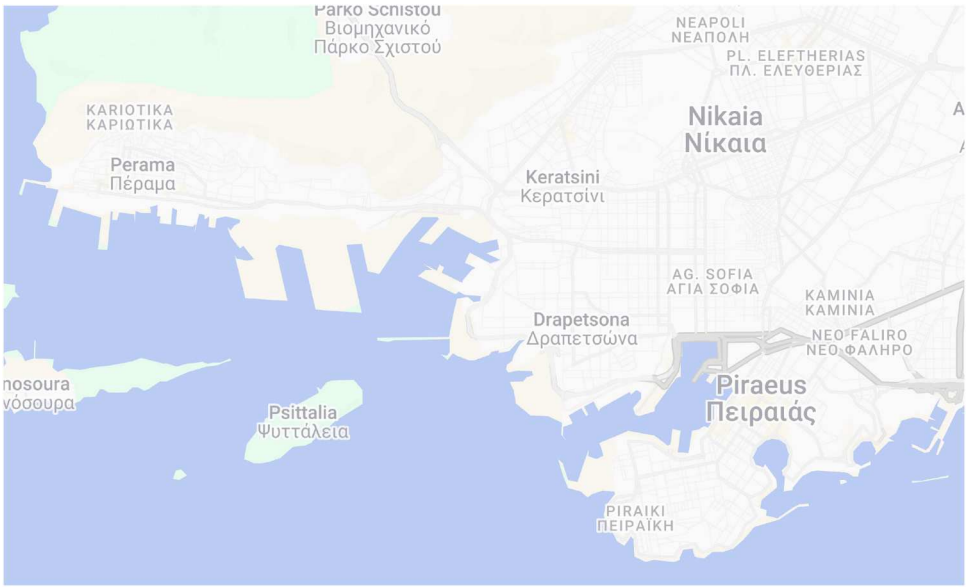


**Figure 1.** Map of Greater Piraeus.

from Asia Minor after the Greco-Turkish wars, who largely settled around the port, shaping the suburbs of Perama, Keratsini and Draptesona. The industries in the port area received a large number of cheap workers and Piraeus became known as a "city of labour" (Bafouni, 2007, p. 35).

The port city was heavily bombed during the Second World War, and many inhabitants moved to Athens. During the 1960s and 70s the military junta incentivized Greek shipowners to bring their companies to Piraeus, the country's first shipping center. While the shores of nearby Drapetsona, Keratsini and Perama were occupied by shipyards, growing working-class municipalities of Greater Piraeus, Piraeus city became a mix of working-class residential, commercial and touristic areas, with pockets of middle-class populations. Nowadays, the urban fabric of Greater Piraeus is a mosaic of diverse urban landscapes and socio-economic classes, which maintain intricate and diverse relationships with port activity. The western side of the Saronic Gulf is characterized by the industrial landscapes of Drapetsona, Keratsini and Perama, with dense social housing surrounding the polluted container port home to an economically disadvantaged population. Piraiki and Pasalimani, on the eastern side of the gulf, are next to the marina and cruise terminals, with a mix of touristy tavernas, 1980s residential buildings and neoclassical bourgeois villas, some in a decayed state. Piraeus center, home to the large passenger port, is predominantly a commercial and residential area, with a mixed population in demographic terms. This social stratification characterizes Piraeus district, and reflecting the different relationships and experiences of port activities and port restructuring.

After a brief, archive-based reconstruction about how different geographies have formed in the surrounding Piraeus port, I conducted several phases of ethnographic research between 2020 and 2024. The objective was to understand the complex interaction between space, power and society driven by the privatization of the port, and what new contested geographies are emerging from this process. I implemented qualitative methods that relied on content analyses of official and press documents and social media including citizens groups, as well as interviews and participant observation. Interviews were conducted with citizens who took and did not take part in the social mobilization against port expansion, lawyers supporting the legal battles of residents, officials from the municipalities around the port and port workers. Their accounts were compared with dominant narratives put out by the city hall and the port authority, which supported my analysis of the ongoing transformation. The interviews were accompanied by multiple visits within and around the port with the interviewees. This gave specific insights into how the port expansion masterplan is altering the socio-spatial relationships of the surrounding territory.

Particular attention was given to exploring the social mobilizations that have taken place around the port since 2018, mainly in the context of Piraiki, where the partially completed and graffiti-ed cruise terminal is planned. Here, inhabitants have been particularly active in contesting the ongoing port restructuring, and so my questions to them intended to mark out the social determinants of protest and their material and immaterial effects in countering the port-driven geographical reshaping.

This paper is not primarily concerned with assessing economic performance indicators, or comparing opposed perspectives on the costs and benefits of port expansion, as the crucial issue it is trying to address is the urban transformation of the city

looking in particular at its liveability, and emphasizing the social and environmental justice dimensions. Hence, interviews focus on how local communities experience the socio-spatial impacts of port expansion, especially amid privatization and economic pressures. This study seeks to foreground the perspectives and lived experiences of residents, and grassroots activists who have varying degrees of material dependency on the port and are affected by its restructuring. Institutional perspectives are already documented in official reports and press releases, which in this analysis have been considered for comparison, allowing the study to critically examine dominant narratives from a grassroots, community-based perspective. By centering on citizens' accounts, rather than institutional narratives from port authorities or corporate stakeholders, the paper seeks to develop an alternative to the dominant perspective, capturing the intricate ways in which port development alters everyday life and fuels social mobilization.

## Geographies of port privatization

### *Port privatization and emerging port-city power relations*

As discussed at the beginning of this article, the port authority of Piraeus was privatized in 2016 and acquired by the Chinese state-owned company COSCO. Integrating it into the BRI (Belt and Road Initiative), this acquisition has structurally transformed power configurations between the port and the city, recasting public and private competencies. The privatized port authority is deploying monopolistic behaviors that are neutralizing previous mechanisms of governance, reducing representative power.

This privatization was supported by the promise of increased logistical competitiveness, seen as a form of "modernization". Discourses on the modernization of ports in EU policies over the last two decades assumed that competitiveness and efficiency were going hand in hand with privatization. This is not intended as an explicit "Thatcherite" model of privatization, as the EU has supported the landlord model of port governance – where port authorities own and manage the land and infrastructure, while private companies are responsible for operating specific terminal services, with the port authority acting as a regulator and facilitator rather than an operator. It is rather a subtle model of privatization through private concession, encouraging competition among private operators to maximize efficiency and profitability in the port and logistics sectors. The privatization and liberalization of port infrastructure had the active support of the European Commission over the last two decades (Karaliotas, 2017). This form of modernization functions as a disruptive innovation, enacting a form of governance that materializes what Swyngedouw (2005) called "governance-beyond-the-state" – fusing together actors, elites, and institutions from national and international levels, creating a distance between governance and democratic accountability. In the case of the privatization of Piraeus, the MoU (Memorandum of Understanding) signed between the Greek State and the Troika of International Institutions (European Central Bank, European Commission, International Monetary Fund) were flexible regarding private involvement in ports.

The extent to which the privatization of Piraeus port was driven by market agents or political actors is disputed; the relationship between the Greek governments in power over the last two decades, maritime elites, shipping companies operating at the port

and the Troika, is intricated and not fully disclosed. The port authority became a corporation (OLP) in 1999, listed on the Athens Stock Exchange in 2003 when the state retained 75%, leaving the door open to private concessions of its terminals. According to Psaraftis and Pallis (2012) it was the conservative government in power in 2004 that promoted the privatization of Piraeus port's terminal, favoring agreements with China over the transference of the terminals to COSCO. When the shipping company MSC, which previously controlled 90% of traffic at the port, opted out in 2009, the Mercantile Marine, Aegean and Island Policy Ministry allowed COSCO to take over the second terminal, through a public bid won by the company. The full privatization of OLP was completed later, following the austerity policies enforced by the Troika on Greece between 2008 and 2017, in which ports, among other infrastructure, were privatized. In this operation, port modernization was presented as a reaction to structural problems of the Greek State, to be resolved through a multiscalar coalition of actors that could implement institutional change.

Differently, Huliara and Petropoulus (2014) claim that Greek shipowners had a decisive impact on the Greek government's decision to seek business relationships with China, but manage to keep a low political profile as they enjoy a privileged tax regime. The privatization of the port authority was supported by the Greek shipping elite, who wanted favorable financial conditions from Chinese banks for using Chinese shipyards (Apostolopoulou, 2020). This sped up Sino-Greek trade relations, which started in the 2000s with the aim of increasing the involvement of Greek-owned shipping companies in the transportation of Chinese goods (Stroikos, 2022).

This process of privatization can also be read through a more relational perspective. The governance of the port can be understood as a multiscalar governance regime, in which spaces of dependence, defined as those more-or-less localized social relations, are tied up to spaces of engagement, intended as entities that engage with other centers of social power at the global level (Cox, 1998). This perspective explains the role of the Greek shipping magnate, not dependent on Piraeus port, but engaged with the Greek and Chinese States to secure their space of dependence (i.e. favorable credit lines.). Greek shipping magnates primarily operate large fleets of bulk carriers, tankers and containerships often unrelated to Greek ports, with revenues gained from contracts with international charters rather than port revenues. They represent a transnational capitalist class, rather than a local one. However, despite the character of contemporary port governance as multiscalar, the privatization resulting from the reorganization of spaces of dependence and spaces of engagement has changed the character of the port infrastructure. It has turned state-run infrastructure into a private business, normalizing the effects of the "glocal governance mismatch". This transformation has exacerbated the already uneven power relationships between transnational and local actors entangled with port transformation – while Greek shipowners, shipping companies operating at the port (COSCO) and the Troika obtained advantages, residents and port workers experience a clampdown on their agency and rights.

The privatization, which turned Piraeus into a BRI flagship, came in effect with restrictions on labor rights and social protection, diving the container handling in two terminals; one of those run by OLP with unionized labor, and the other run by PCT (COSCO's subsidiary) where the company introduced a highly precarious labor regime (Neilson, 2018). As Apostolopoulou (2020) highlights, as well as in other

places where the BRI materializes such as Colombo, Sri Lanka, growing labor insecurity is interconnected with port privatization.

The privatization of Piraeus port is a clear example of how foreign capital tends to discipline state power, reshaping democratic practices, reproducing inequalities, and sparking resistance, aligning with previous literature (Harvey, 2003; Brenner & Theodore, 2003; Sassen, 2014; Klein, 2007). The novelty of the case of Piraeus lies in the shift where power imbalances take place – from the space of port infrastructure to the space of the city, and the disciplining of citizens' ability to influence decision-making. In effect, together with new labor regimes, privatization has shifted the agency on territorial changes. The privatization of OLP has debilitated the processes that guarantee a democratic politics of space. As we see in the next section, despite state approval, COSCO's masterplan of expansion was initially implemented without a strategic environmental impact assessment, and without a proper public consultation, despite citizens continuously requesting dialogue – potentially disregarding the Aarhus convection, which grants the public rights regarding access to information, public participation in decision-making, and access to justice in environmental matters.

Before privatization, issues against the port raised by citizens were often fielded by the local government, but since the privatization, bottom-up initiatives lost efficacy (Tsimonis et al., 2020). While under public ownership, the port authority was ethically obliged to attempt dialogue with the city, embracing the civic functions of an institution governing a significant infrastructure. The privatization of the port authority then reconfigures the relationship between infrastructure, state and citizens, shrinking the influence of the latter and legitimizing and increasing the influence of the privatized port. This new geometry of power enables logistical forces to reconfigure the territory through ruptures with the previous urban order and in the lack of local consensus, turning citizens into passive subjects.

## *A masterplan of ruptures*

In 2016, the Greek state and COSCO signed an agreement that transferred 51% of the port authority's shares to the Chinese corporation, which became 67% in 2021. The concession came with several financial obligations to be undertaken by COSCO over 11 projects, to be coordinated by a masterplan. COSCO's masterplan was initially approved without a strategic environmental impact assessment, and without a meaningful public consultation, despite the complaints of local inhabitants. Citizen contestation, as I explain in the next section, had brought COSCO to court several times, suspending the implementation of its masterplan, rejected due to environmental, technical and financial issues. After eight reformulations, the last approval by the president of the Hellenic Republic at the time of writing was in January 2023.

The masterplan is the instrument through which the interests of the port restructure the city, fostering the previous spatial order towards the supply-chain urbanism paradigm. Like other port cities in BRI's sphere of interest, COSCO's ambitions go far beyond the simply spatial restructuring of the port. As Apostolopoulou (2020) has shown, BRI projects involve more than infrastructure, including real estate and commercial projects. These intentions became palpable across Piraeus district – in the words of one of my interviewees, "the masterplan is not only a port project, it is a city project". The

larger economic restructuring of the port city appears to be an integral objective. "Restructuring" is interpreted here in the classic formulation of Soja (1987) – a sequence of breaking down and building up again; ruptures that shifts the economic, social and political configuration of a place.

Examining the most socially contested projects coordinated by the masterplan, two ruptures became visible as strategies to reformulate the spatial order. The first rupture materializes through the creation of new land reclaimed from the sea destined to be a new cruise terminal. The construction works for the new terminal, designed for receiving 400m-long cruise ship started in 2020. Located in front of Piraiki's very densely populated area, it stands less than 500 m away from local schools and in front of a small beach that plays an important social function for locals. The new terminal aims at exponentially increasing cruise traffic, allowing six more large cruise ships to dock in the port, in addition to the eleven positions already existing. During high season this could mean more than 100 daily buses going back and forth from the new terminal to the Acropolis in Athens – 12 km away. It is necessary here to specify that the project of the cruise terminal was not initially proposed by COSCO, but it was conceived initially by the Greek State in 2012, securing European Commission's financial contribution. However, the matter here is how COSCO brought this idea to fruition, proceeding without consultation or consideration of citizens' perspectives and experiences.

The cruise terminal project is accompanied by a series of other transformations that are taking place in the urban space, outside the port area, turning Piraiki into a "cruise town". Through acquisition and negotiation with the municipality, COSCO is taking over several landmark buildings outside the port's territorial jurisdiction. Its objective is to convert them into five-star hotels, cultural venues and congress centers with the capacity to host around two million tourists annually. The former modernistic station locally known as "pagoda", warehouses on the shore, and historical buildings such as the nautical school and an orphanage in Piraiki will have their usage geared towards tourism. A new metal pedestrian bridge was being designed to be built on the rocky Piraiki shore, part of the historical Themistocles' walls, for tourists to exit the cruise terminal and walk along the Piraiki's promenade. The masterplan is increasing the maximum building in this area by 221%.

The new cruise terminal will rewrite the social metabolism of Piraiki and likely the rest of Piraeus city, altering the way energy, goods, and people circulate through the area. By expanding the port's capacity for large cruise ships, the project directly impacts the flow of tourists and the broader supply chain of goods and services. The structural transformations carried out through this rupture, will redefine the social and economic rhythms of the place; it risks intensifying the dependency on transient economic cycles, which may not provide stable, year-round employment for the local population, thus perpetuating economic inequality.

The second rupture is occurring through land conversion and port encroachment on the urban areas surrounding the commercial port. Land conversion of urban fragments is affecting the coastal area in Keratsini-Drapetsona, a zone that hosts public space and industrial heritage, such as the ruins of a fertilizer factory and a slaughterhouse, conceded to the municipality in 2015. The masterplan considers this as an area for the port's supplementary usage and aims to convert parts of it for "commercial, infrastructural and productive activities", without defining exactly what these activities are. In my interviews

with local residents a common concern emerged; the new urban use would allow an undefined range of transformations – "from the construction of six-storey buildings to a new toxic waste processing plant" – said one of my interviewees. Similarly, on the western side of the coast, COSCO has also tried to appropriate municipal land through conversion in Perama, attempting to demolish the wall defining the physical edge between the port and the city, for expanding the third pier. The corporation claims the area to be under its domain, through the reinterpretation of an unclear topographical map of the concession. Municipal officers and citizens have asked for an immediate end to any unilateral and arbitrary action taken by the PA.

The appropriation of strategic urban areas beyond port infrastructure through land conversion attempts to structurally redesign the geography of Piraeus. It alters the spatial and social relationships between port and city, generating a battle of space and other resources, which embodies the tension between fixity and flow that characterize supply chain-urbanism. However, this flow is not only about the circulation of commodities, but also finance and possibilities for capital reproduction. In fact, the space produced by the port provides speculative horizons for new productive combinations, allowing the transfer of capital from logistics to other sectors. In particular, turning Piraiki into a "cruise town" will have consequences related to sectors beyond logistics and the port industry, such as tourism and real estate. The port-driven spatial restructuring of the city is creating a ground for new profit opportunities, in the name of global financial accumulation by local dispossession. However, since 2018 waves of contestation have risen from different communities across Piraeus district, countering the port-driven spatial reshaping.

## A counter-geography of Piraeus

### *Polyphonic contestations in the port territory*

Since the privatization of the port authority and the presentation of the first version of the masterplan, polyphonic contestations have emerged from local communities around the port. I use this term to describe the phenomenon of protests undertaken by groups of residents and workers within and around the port through the construction of multiple and scattered narratives of contestation centered around spatial, environmental and labor injustices.

During my fieldwork in 2022, port workers' strikes were visible from all over the gulf: queues of containerships waiting to access the port were visual testimonial to the disruption to the port flow. They were contesting the decline in working conditions and standards of workplace security. Since the beginning of the privatization process in 2008, COSCO has implemented practices of precarization through subcontracting and "work on call" practices, reducing trade union power (Apostolopoulou, 2020), with incidents of strikes becoming chronic.

Just outside the port, citizen contestations exposed the invasion of the port on urban space and its impacts on the environment. The most active social mobilization has been taking place in Piraiki, where since 2016 citizens have been organizing marches, public meetings and petitions against the new cruise terminal. More than 5,000 residents signed the petition "No port in Piraiki", which asked COSCO to suspend the cruise

terminal project, citing increased air pollution due to maritime and related road traffic, the deterioration of key public urban and natural spaces including the coast and the local beach, the flagrant disregard for sites of historical importance, and big business' effect on small, local businesses. My interviewees recognized the scale of the impact: "Because of this privatization, COSCO can change a project into another one without any public control"; "COSCO is too powerful, it can change the territory without [any] environmental impact assessment"; "COSCO's philosophy is expansion; it wants our coast, which is where we relax, as we don't have parks in Piraeus"; "Piraeus is becoming COSCO town"; "COSCO has incredible carelessness on environmental and public health matters, it dealt with toxic mud from dredging in a very opaque and dangerous way". As COSCO refused to open any dialogue with civic society, residents the sense of subjugation and distrust is palpable – one of my interviewees described COSCO as a "foreign corporation with unclear intentions".

Some engaged citizens formed a civic list, a group representing the "No port in Piraiki" movement that ran for the municipal election, elected in 2018. The appointment of the civic list aimed to bring the voice of dissent into this decision-making space, but had an effect outside of it too – in the words of one participant, "it gave back hope to the inhabitants, contrasting the aggression and discrimination of those whose power has increased". They continued: "the election of the civic list provided us with courage, opening a possible future for our struggle". This legitimation of the civic struggle boosted the undertaking of a legal battle of citizens against COSCO.

Residents brought the corporation to court, obtaining a temporary victory in 2022: the Supreme Court defined the cruise terminal project as illegal due to the lack of strategic environmental impact assessment. The construction of the cruise terminal was suspended, turning the half-made cruise terminal into a witness of citizens reclaiming their agency, visible from all around the gulf (Figure 2).

Awareness-raising campaigns and public discussion in Piraiki, together with the legal suspension of the cruise terminal, still helped many to make sense of the port city's ongoing transformation. This held the emancipatory potential for the local community in Piraiki, particularly through the inclusion and expansion of ecological perspectives within claims for the "right to the city". These claims problematized the dependencies of the city and their urban life from the surrounding ecosystem, also connecting environmental health to public health.

**Figure 2.** Left to right: The unfinished cruise terminal platform (photo by author); activists sailing on their boat near the platform (photo: "No Port in Piraiki" movement).

Concerns about the exhausting effects of expanding port activity on the environment rose also across working-class Drapetsona and Keratsini, areas that have already suffered from intense port activities over the last decade. Here pollution is exacerbated by the construction of a new container terminal that is depleting already scarce resources such as clean air and sea water. In 2018 a local group of residents brought COSCO to court for environmental crimes committed in the construction of the new container terminal, but without victory. In the same year citizens from Perama, where most port workers live, protested against the space invasion triggered by COSCO's trespassing on municipal land. Some felt the corporation "wanted to trespass [their] houses with their ships" (Papastathopoulou, 2018). With very clear support from regional authorities, they forced the corporation to withdraw (Tsimonis et al., 2020). On the island of Salamina, on the westernmost side of the Saronic Gulf, a group of residents has also been protesting against COSCO's decision to build new repair shipyards in the ancient bay, the site of the Salamina Battle, a foundational event for the creation of Piraeus port. With the same legal archaeological categorization as the Acropolis in Athens, the tombs of Salamina's fighters are visibly neglected, among repair shipyards and a cemetery of rusted vessels. The expansion of the shipyards is hindering local heritage conservation efforts.

### *The observatory of Piraiki-Piraeus: grassroots environmental monitoring as a form of resistance*

During my fieldwork, I grasped glimpses of bonding and expression of solidarity across different protesting communities. On 1 May 2022, different citizens groups that mobilize against the port joined the dockworkers' march from Piraeus city center to COSCO's headquarters. On other occasions, activists from Piraiki met other activists in nearby Salamina and Keratsini-Drapetsona. However, these struggles have never merged into a single, collective voice around the port.

Studies on cross-collaboration in social mobilizations have shown that positionality frequently inform tensions or disentanglements between different groups (Beamish & Luebbers, 2009). In the case of Piraeus, where different communities have different material dependencies on the port – class, political tradition and a certain disconnection due to spatial fragmentation between communities – seem to be behind the scattered actions against the masterplan. Hesitancy surrounding protest and contestation was higher among people whose jobs depend more on port activities. Other interviewees said communities have conflicting interests, while others supposed that political party dynamics have appropriated voices and small victories, crystalizing sectorial reclamations among contesting communities.

Nonetheless, the temporary victory of Piraiki's community resonated across the whole district in an unprecedented way. This victory has shown that COSCO's underestimation of the environmental issue, represents a potential opportunity for those struggles that centers the environment and the urban dependency from it, as revindication. This set up a precedent: for the first time, in March 2023, different collectives and independent organizations from Piraiki, Draptsona, and Perama got together on a rally centered around the environmental justice framework, appealing together to the Council of State to cancel the decree that reapproved COSCO's masterplan. The appeal used new evidence on environmental degradation in multiple locations driven by the port

expansion and impacts on public health; such evidence was collected by the Observatory of Piraiki-Piraeus (the Observatory from now on in the text), initiated by a group of activists from the No Port in Piraiki.

The Observatory emerged during the pandemic when local residents began sharing online images and videos documenting ecological damage caused by COSCO's operations. Initially informal, it was later formalized as a non-profit organization in 2022. The Observatory utilized a resident's small boat to document illegal dredging in the sea and monitor the maritime environment by collecting water samples from various locations in the gulf. As it grew, the Observatory expanded its focus to address the severe lack of environmental data in the area, collaborating with environmental NGOs and universities to conduct scientific research on marine and atmospheric pollution. One of its key projects involved grassroots monitoring of air pollution, particularly nitrogen oxides – dangerous pollutants that severely impact human health. Despite Piraeus's large population and its record of exceeding pollution limits in the Attica region, the city has only one air pollution monitoring station. The Observatory's efforts to gather and disseminate data have been instrumental in tackling the lack of data, as well as filing legal complaints and raising awareness of the environmental toll of port expansion.

The Observatory of Piraiki-Piraeus stands as a novel form of socio-ecological resistance, bridging class and political divides through shared knowledge and collective action. By creating and sharing scientific data, it has enabled a new form of political solidarity that has facilitated communities to unite around a common understanding of the urban and ecological crisis of the port city. This collective knowledge offers a foundation for a counter-geography that challenges the port authority's control and counters the privatized interests that have shaped the city's spatial and economic transformations. Through the Observatory, diverse communities have started new relationships and temporary alliances, finding common ground in their opposition to the port's unchecked expansion, and strengthening their ability to resist, even if this has not been enough yet to negotiate the authority's power more effectively.

## Conclusion

This article has considered Piraeus as a paradigmatic case of port cities facing contested reconfiguration. It analyzed the socio-spatial and political dynamics surrounding the privatization and expansion of the port, examining the forces and the mechanisms of rupture that foster the materializing of what Danyluk (2021) has described as supply-chain urbanism. It exposed how the port privatization has altered the geometry of power between port and city, undermining the processes that guarantee a democratic politics of space, and enabling the establishment of a new socio-spatial order in Piraeus. Through land conversion and land reclamation, among other strategies coordinated by the masterplan, the port is appropriating strategic urban areas beyond port infrastructure, expanding its ground of capital reproduction and generating a battle of space and resources. This embodies the tension between fixity and flow that characterize supply chain-urbanism. However, local inhabitants, are hampering the masterplan, countering its imposed geographical transformation, adopting strategies that center environmental injustices.

The analysis and formulation of these ongoing transformations add to the existing literature on the politics of circulation and the socio-spatial reconfiguration resulting from

logistical transformation, through two main points. The first contribution concerns the forms of urbanization emerging from circulation. I argue that the production of space that characterize the supply-chain urbanism paradigm, is driven not only by the circulation of goods promoted by the logistical sector, as demonstrated in Perama, but also by the circulation of capital from the port towards the city, exceeding the logistical and infrastructural sectors. The active role of COSCO in transforming Piraiki into a cruise town shows that there are distinct modes of urbanizations driven by logistical restructuring.

Secondly, the analysis of citizen contestation emphasizes the relevance of the socio-ecological dimension of supply-chain urbanism and expands on the novel political resistance emerging from it. The case of Piraeus illustrates how narratives of civic struggles that focus on environmental justice offer more potential for socio-political convergence in a fragmented territory than others. Tackling the lack of environmental data in the port territory, grassroots environmental monitoring is producing conditions for new relationships, expanding the terrain of political action. By providing evidence on the environmental degradation driven by the port expansion and its impacts on public health, the grassroots-initiated Observatory of Piraiki-Piraeus is providing alternative narratives to articulate future struggles and imaginaries of the contested port city. The boat initially steered by activists of the "No port in Piraiki" movement, who also form the critical mass of the new observatory, has charted a route for a counter-geography across the Piraeus Gulf.

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## Research ethics and consent

Informed consent to participate in this research for the purpose of data collection and scientific production was provided by the research subjects in written form. Permission has been obtained to publish the figures.

## Data availability statement

There is no data available.

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